

The Reproduction of Capitalist Society

The question of reproduction is central to the historical study of capitalism. In order to persist as a social formation capitalism requires that certain conditions be met, and continually renewed. Some of these are basic to every society - as humans, we require the natural materials that form the stuff of subsistence, and we require human labor to work them into a useable state. It is through this metabolism with nature that we can survive, but this relationship can take many forms. This variety of forms have been analyzed under the category 'modes of production': "a way or manner (a mode) of producing. Of producing what? The material goods indispensable to the material existence of the men, women, and children living in a given social formation."¹ Althusser breaks down this category further into two constituent elements, the forces of production and the relations of production. The forces of production comprise: the *objects of labor*, such as raw materials or sources of energy; the *instruments of production*, such as tools or machines; and the *agents of production*, or the laborers who set upon the objects of labor with their instruments.² Access to each of these three factors in the forces of production must be continually renewed; we must cultivate raw materials or find new sources where they can be extracted, we must maintain our machines and tools, and we must ensure a steady flow of laborers to work them. The structure of these factors - their internal relationships and the conditions of their reproduction - is effected by the relations of production.

Under the capitalist mode of production, there is a strict separation between the agents of production and the instruments and objects they employ in the production process. In other words, the laborers do not own the objects with which they labor - the tools and raw materials are owned by another party who stands outside the forces of production: the capitalist. This means, firstly, that production is controlled not by those who will make use of the commodities produced, but by those who are concerned only with profit. Capitalist production is commodity production, production for the

¹Louis Althusser, *On the Reproduction of Capitalism: Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*, trans. G. M. Goshgarian (Verso, 2014), 22.

²Althusser, *On the Reproduction of Capitalism: Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*, 25.

market. It subordinates the creation of useful things to the creation of profitable things; it is a "mode of production whose overriding objective is to produce, not objects of social utility, but surplus-value and capital itself."³ Secondly, under the capitalist mode of production, workers cannot directly labor to meet their own needs, but must labor for a capitalist in the production of commodities. In exchange for this labor, the capitalist who then pays them enough to survive, but less than the value of what they produce. The reproduction of the laborer becomes mediated by exchange. They cannot grow food because they have no land, and they cannot eat the commodities they produce because they belong to the capitalist. They must resort to exchanging their labor for wages, and their wages for the objects of the labor of others.

This requires some clarification, as these conditions are not universal within the capitalist world-system. If we are to discuss the reproduction of capitalism, we cannot limit ourselves to simply the reproduction of the conditions of wage labor, as even within the core countries, production by means other than wage labor persist. The enslaved laborers in American prisons are not wage-workers, neither are small farmers and agricultural producers, nor petty commodity producers and gig workers that work inside their homes. In what sense do these non-waged social configurations of production belong to the capitalist mode of production? This question has bugged scholars of capitalism who have come up with endless contradictory explanations. Althusser, in the text we have been reading refers to them as "archaic forms" that have been dominated by capital "by virtue of the capitalist market's nearly total domination of the 'small independent producers'."⁴ In other words, although the empirical characteristics of non-waged labor seem to be holdovers from a "pre-capitalist" era, they have nonetheless been reoriented towards production for the market.

Jairus Banaji takes a similar approach, emphasizing the difference between modes of *production*, and modes of *exploitation*. In a discussion of what he calls vulgar marxism, focusing on

Maurice Dobb, Banaji critiques the view that "modes of production were deducible, by a rela-

³Althusser, *On the Reproduction of Capitalism: Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*, 33.

⁴Althusser, *On the Reproduction of Capitalism: Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*, 29.

tion of 'virtual identity', from the given forms of exploitation of labour."⁵ His critique of Dobb and the vulgar marxists who posit a relation of identity between wage-labor and capitalism itself borrows from Lenin's analysis of the development of capitalism in Russia:

Lenin argued, in other words, that as simple-commodity producers are subordinated to the power of capital, in town or village, and specifically bourgeois relations of production develop, far from transforming bondage and serf-forms of exploitation into specifically capitalist forms of exploitation, i.e., those forms which correspond to the 'classical, adequate mode of production of capital', these new relations of production, founded on capital, intensify the existing backward forms of exploitation: these forms remain 'feudal' or 'semi-feudal' in character, while the relations of production acquire a bourgeois character.⁶

The argument that the development of capitalism intensifies the so-called 'pre-capitalist' forms of exploitation is itself not new to Lenin, but is also found in Marx. For Marx wage-labor was not an isolated phenomenon, divorced from any other social configuration. Rather, "the veiled slavery of the wage-labourers in Europe needed the unqualified slavery of the New World as its pedestal."⁷ Crucially, the relationship between wage-labor in the core and 'unqualified slavery' elsewhere is not unidirectional, with unfree labor providing cheap inputs for production based on the wage. The development of capitalist relations transforms other types of exploitation: "as soon as peoples whose production still moves within the lower forms of slave-labour, the corvee, etc. are drawn into a world market dominated by the capitalist mode of production, whereby the sale of their products for export develops into their principal interest, the civilized horrors of over-work are grafted onto the barbaric horrors of slavery, serfdom etc."⁸ What emerges are new and more extreme configurations of slavery, serfdom, etc that did not exist before.

My issue with the above analyses is the characterization of non-waged labor formations as "archaic," "pre-capitalist," "backwards," or "lower forms." While it is true that the history of capitalism has led to an unprecedented expansion of wage labor, it also has created modes of exploitation based on

⁵Jairus Banaji, *Theory as History: Essays on Modes of Production and Exploitation* (Brill Academic Publishers, 2010), 53.

⁶Banaji, *Theory as History*, 56.

⁷Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*, vol. 1, trans. Ben Fowkes (Pelican Books, 1976), 925.

⁸Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1, 345.

more extreme and violent forms of coercion. To consign these to some sort of capitalist pre-history is to deny their specificity to the capitalist world, as well as to overstate the freedom of wage workers. Philip Corrigan writes that "[t]hese forms of coercion should not be conceptualized as residuals from former modes of production and essentially irrational; but as indications of capitalism's expansion."⁹ In this context the thinkers we have cited are useful. The question is not why non waged forms of coercion have persisted, or if they will be swept aside by the progress of history, but how they are transformed and subordinated to the logic of capital: the nearly total domination of the capitalist market.

How is this discussion of modes of production relevant to the reproduction of capitalism? An analysis of social reproduction must look at the conditions for the creation and perpetuation of wage-labor, but it cannot be limited to this. It must include an analysis of the forms of unwaged labor that are internal to the capitalist world system, how these support and are supported by the system of waged labor. Furthermore, it must look at the conditions of accumulation and the domination of the market, how the conditions of this domination are effected and sustained. Keeping these complications in mind, this section will look at three aspects of social reproduction: the reproduction of the abstract category of labor-power divorced from the means of subsistence; the reproduction of specific types of concrete labor; and the reproduction of market domination.

The Reproduction of Labor Power

Marxist feminists have long considered the ways in which the category of waged labor is reproduced and maintained by unpaid domestic labor, often performed by women. In fact, it is difficult to analyze the category of labor power in modern society without also discussing the unique exploitation of women in its reproduction. Lise Vogel ascribes the phenomenon of the oppression of women in capitalist society to the role they play in the generational reproduction of laborers. In her 1983 book *Marxism and the Oppression of Women*, Vogel argues "for the power of Marxism to analyse

⁹Philip Corrigan, "Feudal Relics or Capitalist Monuments? Notes on the Sociology of Unfree Labour," *Sociology* 11, no. 3 (1977): 441.

the issues that face women today in their struggle for liberation” but she “rejects, however, the assumption made by many socialists that the classical-Marxist tradition bequeaths a more or less complete analysis of the problem of women’s oppression” (Vogel 2013, 2). Rather, she contends that the writings of Marx and Engels, as well as certain high-points in the twentieth century Marxist tradition, though they “never adequately addressed the question of women,” contain the kernel of a theory that can be developed into a “theoretical framework in which to situate the problems of women’s oppression and women’s liberation” (2).

Vogel identifies two dominant perspectives on the problem of women’s oppression, one which divorces women's oppression from the context of capitalism, and one which identifies women's oppression with their structural position in capitalist society. Vogel calls these “two essentially contradictory approaches,” (Vogel 2013, 134) the dual-systems perspective, and the social reproduction perspective. In the first approach, “women’s oppression derives from their situation within an autonomous system of sex-divisions of labor and male supremacy” (134). In other words, the oppression that women in modern society face as women differs from the oppression that they face on the basis of class. There are obviously overlaps and intersections between the two, but logically, “the dual-systems perspective implies that women’s oppression follows a course that is essentially independent from that of class oppression” (134). This has been the perspective of much radical feminism in the west, which has been at best agnostic towards anti-capitalism, and often hostile to it.

Vogel is more sympathetic to the social reproduction approach, although she considers it undertheorized. This approach grounds the oppression of women “in their differential position with respect to generational replacement-processes” (Vogel 2013, 135). This situates the analysis of the position of women in society within the “central dynamic of social development in societies characterized by exploitation” (135). As capitalism is a total social system, transforming every aspect of modern life, a historically grounded critique of the oppression of women must take as a central concern the drive for endless accumulation. As the exploitation of labor-power drives accumulation

under capitalism, the social-reproduction approach to the so-called women-question examines the unique role of women in the production and maintenance of labor-power.

However, Vogel points to a much more fruitful analysis of social reproduction. Her book deals extensively with the history of Marxist approaches to the liberation of women, but in the last chapters, she interrogates the question itself: “the first requirement for further motion is to abandon the idea that the so-called women-question represents an adequate category of analysis” (Vogel 2013, 142). She elaborates the useful Marxist framework not as a theory of the position of women in society, but of the “reproduction of labour-power in the context of overall social reproduction” (142). Within this dynamic, women occupy contradictory positions for capital – on the one hand, the potential capacity to produce future workers is necessary for continued accumulation in the long term, but on the other hand bearing children reduces a person’s capacity to perform productive labor for capital: “childbearing potentially entails a costly decline in the mother’s capacity to work, while at the same time requiring that she be maintained during the period of diminished contribution” (Vogel 2013, 151).

Although her conception of ‘woman’ as simply those who have the capacity to bear children is perhaps dubious,¹⁰ Vogel is making a broader point about gender and capital. For Vogel, women are oppressed in capitalist society due to their specific role in generational reproduction, i.e. the specific way in which they are dominated in service of the needs of capital. This consideration brings to the fore the articulation between productive labor and reproductive labor beyond just the question of childbearing. Reproduction entails not only the creation of new and future workers, but also the day-to-day maintenance of present workers and their dependents.

Vogel identifies this day-to-day reproductive labor as domestic labor. Though domestic labor is most often associated with feminized labor in private households, it “also takes place in labour-camps,

¹⁰ For a theoretical critique of Vogel’s transhistorical association of the category of woman with the process of childbearing, see chapter 7 of *Mute Compulsion*, “Capitalism and Difference,” (Mau 2023, 152-173). For a historical explication of the contingent nature of this association, see *Patriarchy and Accumulation on a World Scale* by Maria Mies, especially chapter 3, “Colonization and Housewifization” (Mies 1986, 74-111).

barracks, orphanages, hospitals, prisons, and other such institutions” (Vogel 2013, 159). In other words, the oppression of women through the imposition of unwaged domestic labor is a specific manifestation of the larger phenomenon of reproductive labor within capitalism. Key to Vogel’s insight is that different forms of reproductive labor are utilized to reproduce different forms of labor. It is this larger phenomenon of social reproduction that has been elaborated in a recent trend in Marxist Feminism called Social Reproduction Theory.

Building on the work of Lise Vogel, Social Reproduction Theorists have staked out a formidable project: to reclaim fully half of the capitalist system as an object of study for Marxists. This project is elaborated in the recent celebrated volume *Social Reproduction Theory: Remapping Class, Recentering Oppression*, which defines SRT as “an approach that is not content to accept what seems like a visible, finished entity – in this case, our worker at the gates of her workplace – but interrogates the complex network of social processes and human relations that produces the conditions of existence for that entity.”¹¹ For the scholars working with SRT, this complex network of the relations of reproduction is crucial for the functioning of capital, and they are fundamentally relations of human labor.

This formulation is in direct contradiction to the self-conception of capital, which “acknowledges productive labor for the market as the sole form of legitimate ‘work,’ while the tremendous amount of familial as well as communitarian work that goes on to sustain and reproduce the worker, or more specifically her labor power, is naturalized into nonexistence” (Bhattacharya 2017, 2). Indeed, Marx notes that value in capitalist societies is based not merely on labor-time, but on “socially necessary labor time”¹² an abstraction that elevates the importance of commodity producing labor and devalues all other types. The determination of what instances of labor are considered socially necessary is of course a contingent social process that responds to historical conditions. We will discuss this later in the paper, but for now it is enough to emphasize SRT’s insight that to the extent that

¹¹(Bhattacharya 2017, 2).

¹²cite this

reproductive labor happens outside the realm of commodification, it is “analytically hidden by classical economists and politically denied by policy makers” (2).

Social Reproduction Theory, then, is a theory of this invisible reproductive labor, and an attempt to understand it as constitutive of capitalism. As its state of ‘invisibility’ would indicate, this is far from a simple task. Bhattacharya notes the distinction between public/private to delineate reproduction from production. The life of the worker is divided into two sections: the working day during which the worker is engaged in the production of value, and the space of reproduction, in which the laborers reproduce themselves, or at least their labor-power. The distinction is not so cut and dry, however. These spheres, though “they may be separate in a strictly spatial sense are actually united in both the theoretical and operational sense. They are particular historical forms of appearance in which capitalism as a process posits itself” (Bhattacharya 2017, 9). In fact, production and reproduction are quite messily intertwined.

Referencing an earlier article by Johanna Brenner and Barbara Laslett, Bhattacharya defines social reproduction as inclusive of “how food, clothing, and shelter are made available for immediate consumption, how the maintenance and socialization of children is accomplished, how care of the elderly and infirm is provided, and how sexuality is socially constructed” (Brenner and Laslett 1991, quoted in Bhattacharya 2017, 6-7). By this definition, reproductive labor includes the unpaid activity of mothers as well as waged nannies and daycare workers. It includes “unproductive” teachers in public education as well as “productive” teachers in private schools. The network of reproductive relations is complex, pulsing just under the surface – unified by little other than its relation to labor-power and its devaluation by capital. It cuts across traditional Marxist understandings of labor: it includes both waged and unwaged work, it is sometimes commodified and sometimes not, it is performed by both men and women on both formal and informal bases, and it permeates all institutions of society from the home to the state itself.

The work in Bhattacharya's volume is at its strongest when it takes an expanded view not just of the types of labor required for capitalist accumulation, but of reproduction itself. This expanded view takes seriously Vogel's consideration of the reproduction of labor-power that takes place in "labour-camps, barracks, orphanages, hospitals, prisons, and other such institutions" (Vogel 2013, 159). Reproduction is far more than mere biological reproduction, though that is a crucial aspect. Labor-power is reproduced at several different levels of social organization – in addition to the family, Bhattacharya notes that "[s]lavery and immigration are two of the most common ways capital has replaced labor" (Bhattacharya 2017, 7-8). Societies can and have shifted the requirement to reproduce labor power from local families to the marginalized zones of the world, increasing the influx of workers to a region through invitation or theft. Additionally, the day-to-day reproduction of labor power in prisons and work-camps is performed not by family members, but by laborers themselves on an unwaged basis or by employees dedicated to reproduction, such as cooks or cleaners.

Capital has not, indeed cannot, commodify all aspects of reproduction. It may commodify aspects of care and subsume portions of the sphere of reproduction into production, but it requires as a foundation a matrix of unpaid and devalued life. Just what types of labor are commodified is historically contingent. Nancy Fraser's essay in *Social Reproduction Theory*, "Crisis of Care" articulates this complex relation: "Historically, this work of 'social reproduction' has been cast as women's work, although men have always done some of it too. Comprising both affective and material labor and often performed without pay, it is indispensable to society" (Fraser 2017, 21). Although the existence of this unpaid realm is crucial to the existence of capitalist accumulation, its boundaries are constantly shifting. In fact, its consolidation and denigration as "women's work" has been a relatively recent (in historical terms) configuration: "Splitting off reproductive labor from the larger universe of human activities, in which women's work previously held a recognized place, [industrial capitalist societies] relegated it to a newly institutionalized 'domestic sphere,' where its social importance was obscured" (Bhattacharya 2017, 24).

Fraser positions this domestic sphere not as a universal category, but a contingent one. It is identical neither to unpaid work, nor to reproductive work, but is the lever by which the relationship between unpaid work and reproduction is manipulated. Fraser treats the categories of SRT – domestic labor, reproduction, the family, etc. – not as fixed units of analysis, but as categories to be critiqued. How, specifically, have the configurations of production and reproduction been molded by the demands of value accumulation, and how have those configurations been constitutive of historical modes of capitalism?

Fraser tracks the shifting configuration of social reproduction through three eras of capitalism: the liberal capitalism of the nineteenth century, the state-managed capitalism of the early and mid 20th century, and the present moment of neoliberal financialization. In each of these periods, the relationship between production and reproduction was manipulated in order to relieve the tension of a systemic crisis. Liberal capitalism preferred a free labor market where the reproduction of labor power in the capitalist core was offloaded onto families, as production and reproduction were forced into “separate spheres.” Drawing on Maria Mies notion of ‘housewifization,’ Fraser notes that this configuration of domestic labor in the core was dependent on the massive exploitation and denigration of women’s labor in the periphery.

After the ravages of the two great depressions in the 1870s-1890s and the 1930s, capitalist states reorganized the reproduction of labor-power on a model of state welfare. In this model, states assumed the burden of providing for reproduction, introducing in the US such measures as the minimum wage, social security, expanded public education and other programs of social protection and reproduction. State subsidization was limited, however. It was systematically withheld from workers in the periphery who were again exploited in order to subsidize social reproduction in the core. For the current moment of neoliberalization Fraser notes that there is “a new, dualized organization of social reproduction, commodified for those who can pay for it and privatized for those who cannot, as some in the second category provide care work in return for (low) wages for those in the first” (Fraser 2017,

32). Racialized immigrant workers are often employed in these low-waged domestic jobs – once again supporting the reproduction of other classes, but in this case often in a commodified manner.

At its best, SRT is a powerful critique of the foundations of the capitalist system: the too-often unpaid and devalued work of reproducing labor power. The consideration of reproductive labor as constitutive of capitalist accumulation is an important corrective to masculinist and wage-based analyses of capital. Although it is true that waged labor is crucial to the accumulation of value, the unpaid work of women and racialized men (and especially the work of abject laborers in the periphery) form the conditions of possibility of waged work. The continual devaluation of certain types of labor, especially reproductive labor, is the historical foundation of capitalism.

Too often, however, instead of investigating the complex relationship between production and reproduction, social reproduction theorists have committed to an overly rigid distinction between the two spheres. Although noting that they are part of the same complex of social relations, Vogel insists that “[r]eproduction of labor-power is not, however, itself a form of production” (Vogel 2013, 144). Similarly, in Bhattacharya’s formulation: “SRT points out that labor power itself is the sole commodity ... that is produced outside of the circuit of commodity production” (Bhattacharya 2017, 7). This is only partially true. Bhattacharya is correct that the reproduction of labor power requires activity outside of commodity production, but capital has always been interested in the commodification of reproductive care work. Activities of production and reproduction are not wholly distinct but overlap, and separating them so sharply reduces our ability to theorize, for example, the increasing privatization of reproduction. Capital, though required to offload some portion of the costs of reproduction onto unwaged workers or distant communities, has always retained a keen interest in the commodification of all life. When it has been able to afford producing the requirements of reproduction as commodities, it has done so.

This overly rigid circumscription of the reproductive sphere leads to some significant oversights in Social Reproduction Theory. The biggest shortcoming is the occasional credulous endorsement of

the family as an intrinsically radical space due to its presumed logical separation from production. But the family is not merely an institution that has been harmed by capitalism – it is a fundamentally capitalist institution. When Mohandesi and Teitelman claim that “households have historically served as bulwarks against capitalism” (Mohandesi and Teitelman 2017, 40) they accept at face value capitalism’s paradoxical glorification of the family as a sacred space, untouched by crass commercialism. In fact, the family was formed by crass commercialism, and it exists in (or rather, was disciplined into) its modern form to perpetuate the conditions of reproduction.

The family, in its modern form, is not a transhistorical human organization, but a constituent institution of capitalist production. Immanuel Wallerstein, in his critique of traditional Marxist understandings of proletarianization, implicitly questions the highly idealized view of the family that would later be endorsed by some social reproduction theorists. Noting that capitalism requires and expands the condition of the alienated wage-labor through the historical process of proletarianization, Wallerstein insists that throughout the globe the object of this process has not been the individual wage worker, but the household or family unit. Throughout history, “individuals have tended to live their lives within the framework of relatively stable structures which share a common fund of current income and accumulated capital” (Wallerstein 1983, 23). These structures are generally (but not always) kin-based, and their boundaries are always shifting, in part due to the demands of the market: “It is in the context of such a household structure that a social distinction between productive and unproductive work began to be imposed on the working classes” (Wallerstein 1983, 24). In this formulation, the modern family is not a “bulwark against capitalism” but is an artifact of capital, formed by the pressures of accumulation.

For Wallerstein, the capitalist family/household primarily serves as an income aggregator. As an income pooling unit, the household structures various forms of contribution to the means of subsistence for its members: for Wallerstein income refers to waged income, but also cash transfers, petty commodity production, rent, and subsistence activity. These five categories are combined in various

proportions throughout the world, but generally wage-income is counterposed to the other four:

Wallerstein considers households that depend primarily on wage-work to be proletarian households and considers those which depend primarily on other forms of income to be “semiproletarian households” (by far the larger group). Semiproletarian households are attractive to capitalists as “whenever wage-labor constitutes a substantial component of household income, there is necessarily a floor for how much the wage-earner can be paid” (Wallerstein 2004, 35).

The semiproletarian household organization is promoted by capital in most of the world, as the matrix of non-waged income acts as a subsidy to the reproduction of labor: the developed reproductive sphere depresses wages. However, there are two forces resisting semiproletarianization. “One is the pressure of the wageworkers themselves who seek to be ‘proletarianized,’ because that in effect means being better paid” (Wallerstein 2004, 35). Working families throughout the history of capitalism have preferred family structures that require less unremunerated reproductive labor and have struggled for this in unions and social movements. The second pressure comes from employers themselves, who have a “collective [long-term] need to have a large enough effective demand in the world-economy to sustain the market for their products” (35). In Wallerstein’s conception, the family is a site of many conflicting tensions, but also as a structure that has been organized to aid capitalist accumulation.

The Reproduction of Concrete Labor

In addition to its purpose as an income pooling unit, the household has a secondary role as well. For Wallerstein, the household/family construct’s second role in capitalist society is as the site of ideological reproduction. He argues that:

Households serve as the primary socializing agencies of the world-system. They seek to teach us, and particularly the young, knowledge of and respect for the social rules by which we are supposed to abide. They are of course seconded by state agencies such as schools and armies as well as by religious institutions and the media. But none of these comes close to the households in actual impact. (Wallerstein 2004, 37)

This socialization plays an important role in conditioning future (and present) workers to accept their role as either paid laborers or subsistence laborers, and “results in the internalization of the myths, the rhetoric, and the theorizing of the system” (37). Wallerstein notes that occasionally this socialization can have an anti-systemic orientation, as households often “socialize members into rebellion, withdrawal, and defiance,” however, “antisystemic socialization can be useful to the system by offering an outlet for restless spirits, provided that the overall system is in relative equilibrium.” Further, except in times of structural crisis, “negative socializations may have at most a limited impact on the functioning of the system.”

In an explicit critique of Social Reproduction Theory, Kirstin Munro looks beyond the household/family structure and emphasizes the potentially repressive nature of reproductive labor. Munro’s critique is based in the claim that “Social Reproduction Theory overlooks the contradictory and antagonistic role of the state in the lives of people, as the reproduction of labor power in capitalism proceeds via antagonism and state repression” (Munro 2021, 623). Not only is the household itself a site of ideological reproduction, but the entire matrix of reproductive labor, whether performed for a wage or not, reproduces specific types of labor. Munro notes that the social role of reproductive and care workers such as nurses, teachers, and social workers “is the reproduction of not just any ‘life’ but that of a docile, exploitable worker” (624). When this labor is done by workers employed by the state, it represents not the state’s interest in the wellbeing of its subjects, but its interest in reproducing the specific types of labor historically necessary for the accumulation of capital.

Munro here focuses on non-household sources of reproductive labor: hospitals, schools, and social work organizations among others. These institutions are generally a part of the state, although private versions of them exist in growing numbers. Though considered ‘unproductive’ by capital for the reason that it does not produce commodities, the labor performed by workers in hospitals, schools and social work agencies serves a valuable role for the capitalist system: it disciplines the labor of others. Though the aid this work provides is necessary for the survival of many working class families, Munro

highlights what she perceives as the complicity of these laborers in state repression. In particular, she rejects the characterization of the labor done by these workers as virtuous “life-making,” preferring a more complicated formulation that situates the type of life being made within “a larger process that perpetuates the capitalist organization of society” (Munro 2021, 625). Indeed, “if exploitation and domination are inherent to the organization of production and reproduction in capitalism, then the reproduction of capitalist society proceeds by perpetuating these forms of organization” (625).

Munro’s critique of Social Reproduction Theory provides the impetus for the investigation central to this paper. While welcoming the achievement of SRT in its attempt to “overturn Marxist orthodoxy and shed light on the importance of unproductive labor carried out by disproportionately women of all races and racialized men” (Munro 2021, 623), she rejects an uncritical view of the reproductive sphere and care-work as virtuous or revolutionary that is common (though not universal) in the writing of social reproduction theorists. In positioning the reproductive sphere as constitutive of capitalist accumulation and complicit in the repression of workers, she opens up the following question: How have the specific historical configurations of the reproduction of labor power – “the cultural norms that prescribe working class ‘needs,’ the specific proportions of inputs, the social assignment of tasks, and the arrangement of people in space” (Munro 2021, 624) – been manipulated to fulfill the specific historical need of capital for certain types of workers.

We have pointed out that the claim by SRT that labor power is produced “outside the circuit of commodity production” is only partially true. Indeed, Marx notes in volume 1 of *Capital* that “the ultimate or minimum limit of the value of labour-power is formed by the value of the commodities which have to be supplied every day to the bearer of labour-power, the man, so that he can renew his life-process” (Marx 1976, 276). The value of labor power is, as for all other commodities, defined precisely by the extent to which it can be produced within the circuit of commodity production. This overlap between production and the reproduction of labor power is crucial because it represents an axis on which the value of labor power can be manipulated. If the value of the commodities required for

renewing life-processes can be cheapened by the offloading of reproductive labor to unpaid or underpaid workers, then the value of labor drops as well.

The process devaluing labor by increasing the burden of uncommodified domestic work is not applied evenly to the working classes. Capital may value commodities based on an abstraction of undifferentiated labor power in various amounts, but it requires for the production process concrete acts of labor in various configurations and at various prices. Treating labor power as an undifferentiated mass may help us understand the logic of exploitation in a society based on generalized exchangeability, but in order to understand the historical configuration of production and reproduction in a given time and place, we must disaggregate this mass into its component parts. In other words, to build on Munro's critique, what is reproduced by domestic and unproductive laborers is not merely life, or labor power, but the specific kinds of concrete labor required by capital.

The Reproduction of the Market

Domestic and reproductive labor serves another crucial purpose for capital, in addition to its role in the reproduction of labor. The household is the primary institution responsible for renewing the life-force of commodity producers, but it is also the final destination of most of the commodities produced. Althusser writes that the family "is a *unit of consumption* in our societies. It is not the only kind of unit of consumption there is, but, of those in existence, it is a kind that still plays an extremely important part and it is not about to disappear."¹³ Although many industries are involved in the production of machines or tools that are themselves not directly consumed in private households, these can be seen as intermediate links in the commodity chains which terminate in the home: e.g. tractors and looms are built and sold as commodities, but are subsequently employed in the production of grain and cloth for clothes. This grain and these clothes are then purchased and consumed in the household in

¹³Althusser, *On the Reproduction of Capitalism: Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*, 77.

what Munro calls the "household production process."¹⁴ The household production process is not external to the circulation of capital, but is one of its main components.

For Munro, the household production process is linked to both the state and firms, as it "is forced to rely on capitalist firms and the state to ensure the survival of its members, both day-to-day and intergenerationally; it in turn contributes to the perpetuation of capitalist society."¹⁵ In other words, we cannot isolate the household from broader capitalist society and identify it exclusively with the reproduction of labor. It must be theorized as part of a larger process: "[t]here is no social reproduction without 'societal reproduction,' as all production and reproduction in capitalist society are indelibly shaped by accumulation."¹⁶ This means that households are complicit in the reproduction of the very conditions of their unfreedom. They are separated from the direct means of subsistence and forced to rely on commodity consumption in order to survive; in so doing, they valorize capital and provide the conditions of profitability that make endless accumulation possible.

This framework has important implications for the study of class struggle. If capital can make use of both devalued labor that is heavily dependent on unpaid reproductive work, as well as highly-paid labor that is supported by more extensive commodity consumption, then a 'win' for the working class is not necessarily a 'loss' for capital. Postone writes that "manifestations of class struggle between the representatives of capital and the workers over working-time issues or the relationship of wages and profits, for example, are structurally intrinsic to capitalism, hence an important constitutive element of the dynamic of that system."¹⁷ The implication is that such struggles over the distribution of surplus are internal to capitalism: if the goal of class struggle is merely higher wages for the workers, or the ownership of a larger portion of surplus, then the success of the working classes means a decrease in

¹⁴Kirstin Munro, "'Social Reproduction Theory,' Social Reproduction, and Household Production," *Science & Society* 83, no. 4 (2019): 451–68.

¹⁵Munro, "'Social Reproduction Theory,' Social Reproduction, and Household Production," 454–455.

¹⁶Munro, "'Social Reproduction Theory,' Social Reproduction, and Household Production," 455.

¹⁷Moishe Postone, *Time, Labor, and Social Domination: A Reinterpretation of Marx's Critical Theory* (Cambridge University Press, 1993), 36–37.

the amount of capital available to be re-invested, but at the same time an expanded base of consumption through which the capitalist relations of production are reproduced.

The remaining sections of this paper will explore this tension in the context of industrial Michigan. As the Fordist revolution changed the way that capital is produced, it was accompanied by a revolution in the relations of reproduction. The relations of production were reproduced through transformed relationships between wage-labor, unpaid domestic labor, and commodity consumption. We will examine the extension by capital of new types of control over the private lives of workers in an attempt to tease out how specific configurations of household reproduction supported the new productive regime.